

[Return to Search](#)

Religion, morality, and the person

Author(S): Fortes, Meyer, Goody, Jack

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 207

Culture (OWC): [Tallensi \(FE11\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1934-1937; 1971

Coverage Date: 1930-1971

Place Coverage: Tongo Village, Ghana

Section Title(S): The Tallensi Family System

It is significant that each wife has her own quarters in the homestead, reserved for herself and for her children, and her husband must come to her there. Husband and wife have distinct but complementary spheres of economic activity and of social and moral responsibility. They also keep their separate social identities as members of their respective clans throughout life. What they share is above all exclusive procreative sexual relations and parenthood, and they must co-operate to maintain the family. Thus from a filial point of view, and in the child's experience, father and mother represent precisely differentiated, complementary and mutually dependent spheres of life. Through their father children are united in common membership of lineage and clan, symbolized in common clan taboos and in dependence on common ancestors. This is the source of jural status carrying rights and duties that link one to society at large. Mothers, in contrast, split up patrilineal siblings linking each group of maternals to their mother's kin and ancestors and thus differentiating them from their paternal siblings. So closely identified are a mother and her children that they are deemed to be of one spiritual substance, united not by right and duty but by spontaneous generosity and love. Mother's brother is therefore the classically affectionate gift-giving uncle devoid of authority but free to protect. Father wields authority and discipline by unquestionable status right He will, in anger, chastise a disobedient child; but he is also responsible for his children to society at large and must be sufficiently affectionate and protective to fulfil his socializing tasks and bind his children to himself by trust as well as duty. Mother, in contrast, gives nurture, comfort and above all food, freely out of love. She may scold, she will not chastise a child. She is obeyed not out of duty, as with father, but out of love, and in return submits to unlimited demands. The attachment of men and women to their querulous old mothers is touching to see. For both parents, it must be emphasized, children are a source of pride and fulfilment.

342

Dwellings

593

Family Relationships

602

Kin Relationships

861

Techniques Of
Socialization

Across this division runs the generation sequence clearly marked ■ 208 by custom. In contrast to the cleavage between parents and children, siblings are on equal and familiar terms, though rivalry is acknowledged particularly between consecutive children of the same mother. Deference and respect for their conjugal privacy, amounting to a mild avoidance associated with the incest taboo is proper in relation to parents. But with parents' parents one has a joking relationship, which reconciles respect for the paternal grandfather's authority with the affectionate trust in the relationship of alternate generations that is found in most human societies, and serves as a foil to the deferential obedience due to the father. Father's mother is the acme of indulgence, for unlike mother she never has to forbid or scold and feels no responsibility for a child's conduct. And in the background are the ancestors made very real when sacrifices and libations are offered on their shrine. Far from being excluded, children are particularly drawn into these ritual activities.

593

Family Relationships

602

Kin Relationships

603

Grandparents And
Grandchildren

861

Techniques Of
Socialization

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.eduIssues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu

